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Barton Rates Orsatti as Millers' Greatest Player

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Sports Writer

When the loss of a pennant can be attributed to a club being deprived of the services of one player during the closing weeks of a championship baseball race, it is justifiable to hail him as the most valuable player on his team.

For that reason, I regard Ernie Orsatti, outfielder on Minneapolis' fine team of 1928, as the most valuable player ever to wear a Miller uniform during the 43 years I actively reported baseball from 1904-1946, inclusive.

THE MILLERS of 1928 were nosed out by Indianapolis for the pennant during the last three days of the season.

Charles Johnson of the Minneapolis Star, Halsey Hall of the Minneapolis Tribune were of the opinion the Millers lost the pennant because they concluded the season with two series each with the Kansas City and Milwaukee teams which were fighting for third place. On the other hand, Indianapolis played the same number of games with Toledo and Columbus, which finished seventh and eighth, respectively.

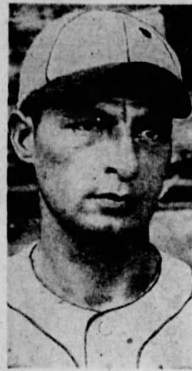
Not so, the late Mike Kelley, owner and manager of the Minneapolis team, said. He blamed the recall of Orsatti in mid-August by Branch Rickey, president and general manager of the St. Louis Cardinals. Orsatti was owned by the St. Louis club and farmed out to Minneapolis.

"IF RICKEY had permitted Orsatti to finish the season with us, we would have been so far ahead of Indianapolis by September first it would have been impossible for them to catch up with us," Kelley told Charlie, Halsey and myself.

"Orsatti was the difference between winning and losing the pennant. His timely hitting, speed on the bases and remarkable defensive playing in the outfield played a vital role in keeping us in first place and far ahead of Indianapolis, Milwaukee, Kansas City and St. Paul.

"Moreover, Buster (Mike's pet name for Orsatti) was the spark plug of the team. He kept everybody hustling."

Kelley never was lavish in his praise, consequently when he expressed such high regard for the fiery and colorful little Italian-American baseball



ERNE ORSATTI

player from Los Angeles, Orsatti, goes down in my book as the most valuable player ever to wear a Miller uniform.

NOW THAT you have Kelley's appraisal of Orsatti, I might add he was nosed out by one point by Bobby Veach of the Toledo club for the American association batting championship in 1928—Veach .382, Orsatti .381.

Ernie, in 123 games, garnered 171 hits, including 32 doubles, 15 triples and 14 home runs for a total of 278 bases.

Joining the Cardinals in the middle of August, Orsatti helped immeasurably in winning the National league pennant in 1928. Ernie also aided the Cardinals in winning other pennants in 1930-31-34 and the World Series in 1931-34.

Had it not been for Kelley's high appraisal of Orsatti, I would have been in a quandary in attempting to name the most valuable Minneapolis player I have watched perform in more than 40 years as an active baseball reporter at Nicollet park.

OTHER PLAYERS in my most valuable category were Jimmy Williams, in my book the greatest second baseman ever to play in the American association and likewise one of its greatest hitters. He helped the Millers win three pennants in a row in 1910-11-12.

Other great players were pitcher Tom Hughes, who won 31 games in 1910; Roy Patter-

son, with 24 in 1911; Fred Olmstead, with 28 in 1912; Dick (Mutt) Williams, with 29 in 1915 when he pitched in 86 games, and Earl Yingling, with 24 in 1916.

Then there were Spencer Harris, stellar outfielder and hitter; and Andy Cohen, classy second baseman, both of whom performed yeoman service for the Millers over 10-year periods.

Also Joe Hauser, Nick Culp and Ab Wright, mighty home run hitters and sterling defensive players; Wally Smith and Morley Jennings, outstanding third baseman and shortstop, respectively, and likewise dependable hitters; and that uncanny ball hawk and fiery competitor, Hub Walker.

Here Are Crowd Marks City Fans Hope to Exceed

Minneapolis baseball fans, steamed up over the new Bloomington stadium, have some high attendance marks to shoot at this season. The minor league attendance record is a staggering 640,643 set by San Francisco in 1947.

The American Association mark was established by Indianapolis in 1948 at 494,455.

Here are some of the top minor league attendance figures of the past:

1947, San Francisco (Pacific Coast) ..	640,643
1948, San Francisco (Pacific Coast) ..	606,563
1949, Seattle (Pacific Coast) ..	545,434
1948, Indianapolis (Association) ..	494,455
1950, Seattle (Pacific Coast) ..	492,647
1949, Montreal (International) ..	473,798
1951, Seattle (Pacific Coast) ..	465,727
1952, Denver (Western) ..	461,419
1947, Montreal (International) ..	442,485
1955, Denver (Association) ..	426,248
1951, Denver (Western) ..	424,065
1949, Indianapolis (Association) ..	413,973
1954, Toronto (International) ..	408,876

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Took 37 Innings To Play One Game

Ever hear of two teams playing four games to decide one?

The Millers shared in the experience against Indianapolis in 1913. They went to a 1-1 tie in six innings April 25, rain halting things. On June 15 darkness stopped the replay at 6-6 in the ninth. They tried again Aug. 7 and this time went through 13 frames before darkness made 'em quit at 2-2.

They finally made it, though. The next day the Millers sewed it up 11-1 in regulation nine innings. But they'd gone through 37 innings to win.